Chapter 3.

THE STATE OF THE WORLD

Understanding the Landscape

When PM Modi declared in Samarkand in September 2022 that *this is not an era of war*, the statement resonated across the world. It did so naturally because of its immediate context. But the message also captured the interdependence of our world that has now made conflict very dangerous for everybody. In a sense, it was a caution as well to others who may be contemplating their own options. The fact that such a pronouncement had to be made at all is a reflection on the fragility of the current global order. That it was in transition was already well recognized. But that this process could take the forms we are witnessing today was anticipated by very few.

In 2020, when I wrote *The India Way*, the world already appeared uncertain and unpredictable. Little did we know at that time that we hadn't seen anything yet. In the years that have passed, we have been traumatized by the Covid pandemic, impacted by the Ukraine conflict, grappling with a new level of violence in West Asia, afflicted by frequent climate events and subjected to serious economic stress. They have aggravated both an East–West polarization and a North–South divide. If there is continuity with my earlier endeavour, it is in the underlying phenomenon of how nation states, still the key concept of international relations, struggle with the problems of globalization. This applies as well to the main takeaway: that the world matters for each one of us as never before. As we consider that, the question confronting every Indian is about what our value, weight and prospects are in the contemporary era. We do so not knowing what even the immediate future holds because the pace of technological, economic and social change has accelerated so much. This is no longer an issue of more variables; we are really moving into uncharted territory. Naturally, at such a moment, it is worth reflecting on how our forebears dealt with the uncertainties of their